Saqib Shaikh

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Mission-driven product and engineering leader with 20 years at Microsoft, combining emerging AI capabilities with user needs to build human-centered AI products that improve people's lives.

2026–Present — Microsoft, Project Solara

Incubating new agent-first device experiences.

2015–2026 — Microsoft, Seeing AI

Founded Seeing AI at a hackathon and demonstrated an early multimodal AI glasses prototype onstage with Satya Nadella in 2016. Led the team for a decade, combining emerging AI capabilities with a deep understanding of user needs to build a visual assistant with and for the blind and low-vision community. Grew the product to approximately 200,000 monthly active users across 80 countries and 33 languages.

Seeing AI has received over 20 awards and honors, including recognition from the FCC, Mobile World Congress, and Fast Company. Microsoft also named it one of the "15 milestones that shaped Microsoft's vision for AI" during its 50th anniversary celebrations.

Selected contributions:

- Led product vision and roadmap, working directly with blind and low-vision users to identify unmet needs and translate feedback into product experiences.
- Personally built the first version, then led technical architecture and evolution across deep learning, audio augmented reality, multimodal generative AI, and emerging agent experiences.
- Managed and mentored a team of up to 11 engineers and a PM.
- Developed partnerships with startups and enterprises, including Haleon and WPP, bringing manufacturer-provided product information into Seeing AI and supporting an award-winning TV/radio advertising campaign. Explored new experiences with Apple and Meta hardware.
- Represented Microsoft and communicated the potential of AI for good, including presentations to the UK Prime Minister and House of Lords, and appearances on Bill Nye's Netflix show and Trevor Noah's program.
- Led the team through UK and EU medical-device regulatory compliance.

Earlier Experience

- 2009–2015 — Microsoft, Bing: Developed web-scale services and data processing pipelines to power features including autocomplete, related searches, and sitelinks.
- 2006–2009 — Microsoft, Customer Success Engineering: Worked with customers from large enterprises to government departments and startups to build solutions on the latest Microsoft platforms.
- 2004–2005 — Vodafone

Education

- 2004 — MSc Artificial Intelligence, University of Sussex, EPSRC scholarship
- 2003 — BSc (honours), University of Essex, Top of Class

Volunteering

- 2024–Present, FIRST Lego League, Team Coach.
- 2024–Present, Bricks for the Blind, Instruction Tester.
- 2023–Present, Boy Scouts of America, Den Leader.